ERA 25

Contemporary America

2008 – Present

The Great Recession · a changing people · a nation's challenges

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

What defines America in the 21st century—and what challenges lie ahead?

KEY TERMS

The Great Recession · the Affordable Care Act · demographic change · climate change

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 9.5–9.6 · AMSCO Ch. 9.5–9.6

AMERICA IN A CHANGING WORLD

A New Century

The Great Recession

I

The Crash

A **subprime mortgage** collapse triggered a financial meltdown in 2008.

II

The Bailout

Congress passed **TARP** to rescue banks and stabilize the economy.

III

The Fallout

Millions lost homes and jobs in the worst downturn since the Depression.

The Obama Era

I

A Historic Election

In 2008, **Barack Obama** became the first Black president.

II

Health Care Reform

The **Affordable Care Act** (2010) expanded health coverage to millions.

III

A Slow Recovery

The economy healed gradually amid deep **political polarization**.

A Changing People

- Since the **Immigration Act of 1965**, newcomers from Latin America and Asia reshaped America.
- By the 21st century, the U.S. was more **diverse** than ever.
- Debates over **immigration** became central to national politics.



A Diverse Nation



- **Demographic change** is remaking the American population.
- **Multiculturalism** reshaped culture, food, faith, and politics.
- America continues to redefine what it means to be American.

A Warming World

- **Climate change** emerged as a defining challenge of the century.
- Debate raged over fossil fuels and **renewable energy**.
- The U.S. faced hard choices about energy, the environment, and the future.



America's Challenges

I

A Divided Politics

Deep **political polarization** tested American democracy.

II

A New Rivalry

A rising **China** and a connected world reshaped global power.

III

A Global Crisis

The **COVID-19** pandemic upended life and revealed deep divides.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Contemporary America

1. The **Great Recession** of 2008 was the worst economic crisis since the Great Depression.

2. **Obama's** election and the **Affordable Care Act** marked a historic new direction amid **polarization**.

3. A more **diverse** America faces defining challenges—**climate change**, a rising **China**, and **COVID-19**—as it moves through the 21st century.

DISCUSS & APPLY

Contemporary America

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain the causes and consequences of the **Great Recession**.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How has **immigration** reshaped the American population since 1965?

ARGUMENTATION

What is the most pressing challenge facing 21st-century America? Make and defend a claim.

That's the final era — from 1491 to today. Time to review for the exam!